About Dialogue and Communication[1]

"Beyond what is right or wrong, there is a garden. I will meet you there."

Introduction to dialogue

The word *dialogue* means many things today depending on where you hear it, and from who. The term can indeed be understood in different ways, but is often used to describe different types of communication with an emphasis on listening to each other.

However, when working with peacebuilding and conflict transformation, dialogue is a specific communication tool for building understanding and relations between individuals or groups, which is often used in transforming conflicts. Dialogue has been successfully used in countless of situations throughout history and in all societies. It has been used at interpersonal levels to settle personal disputes, and as parts of longer peace processes around conflicts between groups.

Dialogue has been described in different ways:

> *"Dialogue is an unfolding process of transforming and deepening understanding of others and ourselves through listening, sharing, critical thinking, and questioning. The outcomes of which may be unclear."*
>
> *"Dialogue is not only listening to what the others say, but also trying to understand why they say it."*
>
> *"Dialogue is a form of communication, cooperation and change."*

In short, we define dialogue as a tool for communication that is based on active listening and has the potential to build understanding, strengthen relations and create change within those practicing it. Dialogue builds on honest and sincere exchange of opinions, positions, interests, and needs, focusing on better understanding the other actor and its perspectives, often also deepening the understanding of one's own perspectives. In this way, dialogue carries with it the potential of being transformative, as it can open the mind to new ideas, especially in relation to conflicts and relationships. Some dialogue can be done directly, sometimes it can need the support of a third party facilitator.

Dialogue is distinguished from other forms of communication, as it does not pursue what is "objectively" right or wrong, but instead focuses on the exchange between different perspectives. Below you see a visualization that helps us define dialogue in relation to other types of communication:

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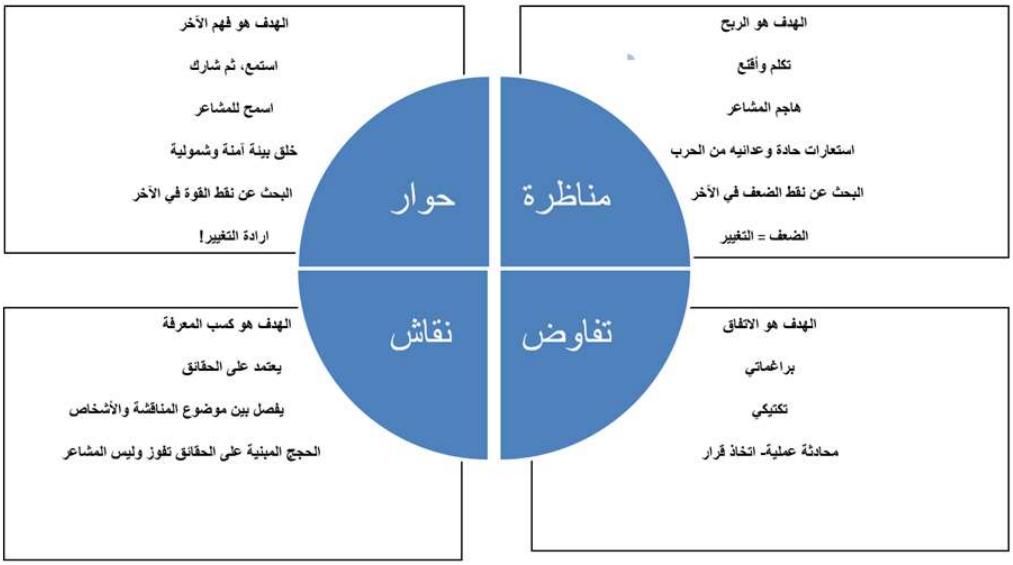
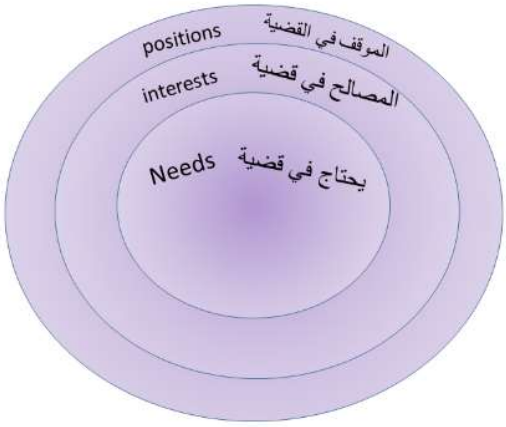
[1] The information is a written complement to the sessions on dialogue in The Maghreb Project and can be used as a reminder of the theories and concepts covered. The information is based on SweFOR's manuals for dialogue and the consultancy work of Bassem Maher Sedra.



Overview of forms of communication, drawn on Steinar Bryn and Dag Hareide , **Irene Incerti-Théry (2016)**

Dialogue is clearly distinguished from other types of communication as there is a will to change, a curiosity of the other party's perspective and that feelings and subjectivity is welcomed. Sometimes it might be difficult to distinguish dialogue form discussion. A simple way to differentiate is that dialogue can be more personal and subjective, not necessarily relying on external facts or logic.

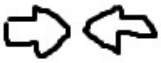
Dialogue can be useful in a lot of different ways. It is useful when trying to build new relations or deepening existing ones, as well as learning about a subject or a shared problem that the parties involved can explore together. In terms of dealing with conflict, dialogue can serve as a very useful tool to help bridge differences between conflicting parties, creating a shared understanding of a problem, as well as getting to the core of a sensitive issue beyond stated positions. This in turn can lead to identifying new solutions to old problems and conflicts, and strengthen relations in polarized and fragmented contexts. In this way, a dialogue process can have a transformative potential in conflicts, as it can lead to a strengthened communication and a more constructive approach to the other actor and the issue at hand. In a conflictual relation, it might be difficult to engage in direct dialogue with the other party, as the communication often tends to change into the form of debate. In this case, a trusted impartial third party actor can be a part of the dialogue process as a facilitator.



This model is called "the onion" and is used to describe the different levels of conscious and sometimes subconscious motivations that people and groups may have around contested topics. Oftentimes, a strong *position* in an issue is based on an underlying *interest*, which in turn is based on an additional and more fundamental *need.* By becoming aware of this, one might become more open to soften a previously strong position, and opening up to find other ways to satisfy the basic need of the other actor/s as well as your own. Dialogue can be a good tool to get past typical positioning in issues, and learn about why that position is taken, and in what need it is fundamentally based. In doing this, new solutions to a conflict or a problem can become visible, as the underlying need can be addressed in new ways. This can be used both to understand the motivations of the other persons or groups, as well as yourself and your own groups' motivations.

Basic requirements for dialogue

While dialogue can be very useful, it can also be a process that is hard to achieve. There are certain basic requirement that are needed for a dialogue to be possible:



There needs to be a **will** amongst the parties to engage in dialogue, and to sincerely talk and listen to the other. If only one party wants to have a dialogue, the result will probably be disappointing. Here it is also important that all parties have the same understanding of what dialogue is, and not confusing it with other types of communication[2]. Doing dialogue with someone who is debating back is neither fun nor constructive.

There needs to be enough **trust** between the parties. Without enough trust, the communication will be limited and probably not sufficiently honest. This part can be supported by a trusted third party who facilitates the process, who can help in gradually building trust between the two parties.

There needs to be enough **time** for the dialogue. This is partly in relation to the *trust,* which is something that is built gradually and which takes time. Also, even when there is enough trust, a dialogue can continue for a long time, as one might discover new areas and great complexities that might take time to grasp for all partaking in the dialogue. Some dialogue processes are also helped by pauses, which can help thoughts to ripen.

Equity is important for dialogue to be possible. This relates to the point about "will", as in the case of two parties of a conflict, where one has far more power than the other, they might not be interested in listening to the inferior party. Likewise, the inferior might be discouraged to engage in dialogue with a superior party, as it might seem pointless. However, as there are many dimensions of power, this aspect is often something that can be interpreted in different ways, depending on the relations between those involved in the dialogue. For example, as dialogue connects a lot to relationship building, it can be possible to counter inequity by balancing the power among those who participate, making sure that all individuals involved are equally included and treated with the same respect, even though their conflict outside the room might be asymmetrical.

A dialogue requires a **safe space** where the parties can talk openly without fear. Safe spaces connect to *trust*, and can be difficult to find in hardened conflicts where opposing positions are manifested strongly, and each side is careful not to break away from its collective narrative. For the dialogue to have a transformative power, the exchange needs to be reflective and honest, especially when talking about sensitive matters and presumably locked positions. The safe space can mean both a physical room where there is possibility to speak freely without disturbance from the outside, as well as in psychological terms, in relation to trust between the parties present. For this, a third party that facilitates the dialogue can be of use, since they can help define and guard some mutually agreed rules for the dialogue.

[2] See "different forms of communication", page 2.

In order to have a safe space, it is necessary to clearly define and agree on a set of **ground rules** for the process, in order to set a clear frame and a mechanism for accountability during and after the dialogue. The ground rules could touch on the following things: Sharing the space and time equally, not interrupting the other, using active listening, deciding on confidentiality, etc.

Finally, a successful dialogue needs a certain level of **communication skills** among those taking part. When talking about sensitive topics with an adversary in a conflict, there are lots of pitfalls – not least falling into heated debate trying to persuade the other (or the third party) of you being objectively right. Risks are that the communication leads to exacerbate the conflict or tension, leading into a failed dialogue. Even though fights can possibly prove to be a good learning moment for an experienced facilitator to use to advance the dialogue, it can also be damaging. By emphasizing certain ground rules or agreements for how to communicate in the dialogue, these situations can be better handled, and leave room for honest and clear communication. A concrete example of suitable style of communication is *nonviolent communication*[3].

Main skills of dialogue

In order to take part in or to facilitate a dialogue that is transformative in nature, it is helpful if the parties and a facilitator, if such a person is present, uses certain skills:

- **Active listening.** In order to improve mutual understanding and trust, an empathetic way of listening and responding has to be practiced, whether by the participants or the dialogue facilitators. Active, empathetic listening provides an opportunity for an accurate interpretation of the person speaking's message and then provides an appropriate response. Active listening aims at building trust, enabling the release of emotions, reducing tensions, encouraging the surfacing of information and creating a safe environment for collaborative problem solving.

- **Rephrasing.** This is an important tool in dialogue facilitation that helps communicators to better understand each other, bring more reflective responses, move the conversation to deeper levels, create a buffer between statements to slow down the conversation and launder vicious or insulting statements by making them less inflammatory while preserving the essential points. Characteristics of good rephrasing are:
    - Mirrors the meaning of the speaker's words, without repeating them exactly.
    - Does not judge or evaluate, only describes.
    - Keeps the focus on the speaker, not the one who is paraphrasing.
    - Paraphrases should be shorter than the speaker's own statement.

[3] NVC is a specific form of communication developed by Dr Marshall B Rosenberg which aims to create a honest and clear exchange where the speaker recognizes the subjectivity of thieir lived experience and opinions, and avoids placing blame and generalizing about known truths, as it also is a subjective experience. More about this can be found on page 8.

- **Summarizing.** This is similar to rephrasing, but it condenses the content of several comments that may have been said over the course of many minutes. Summarizing aims to review all the key points that have been brought forward, thus communicating what was understood through the conversation. It also can be used to keep the discussion focused whenever it would expand in too many directions at once.

Active communication skills include specific steps that make you better in learning and understanding the person you are communicating with, both as a sender and a receiver. The following aspects are important to remember and to take into account when trying to communicate actively, and are at the core of dialogue.

The ear has to do with active listening, being present and trying to understand the message that the sender is giving you, including what they mean with saying it. This can be done by rephrasing, or asking questions of clarification if in doubt about the message.

The eye is connecting to the body language and what are the visible signs of active listening and talking. An active listening body language is contributing to a feeling of connection, which helps often makes the sender feel more confident to share their message. One example is eye contact or that the receiver has a body posture that is directed towards the sender, clearly showing that they are open to listen to the message.

Undivided attention is the combination of the two above mentioned aspects, where the receiver gives its full attention to the person talking and affirms its understanding or lack of understanding by rephrasing and asking questions for clarification, signaling that s/he wants to know and understand what is being communicated.

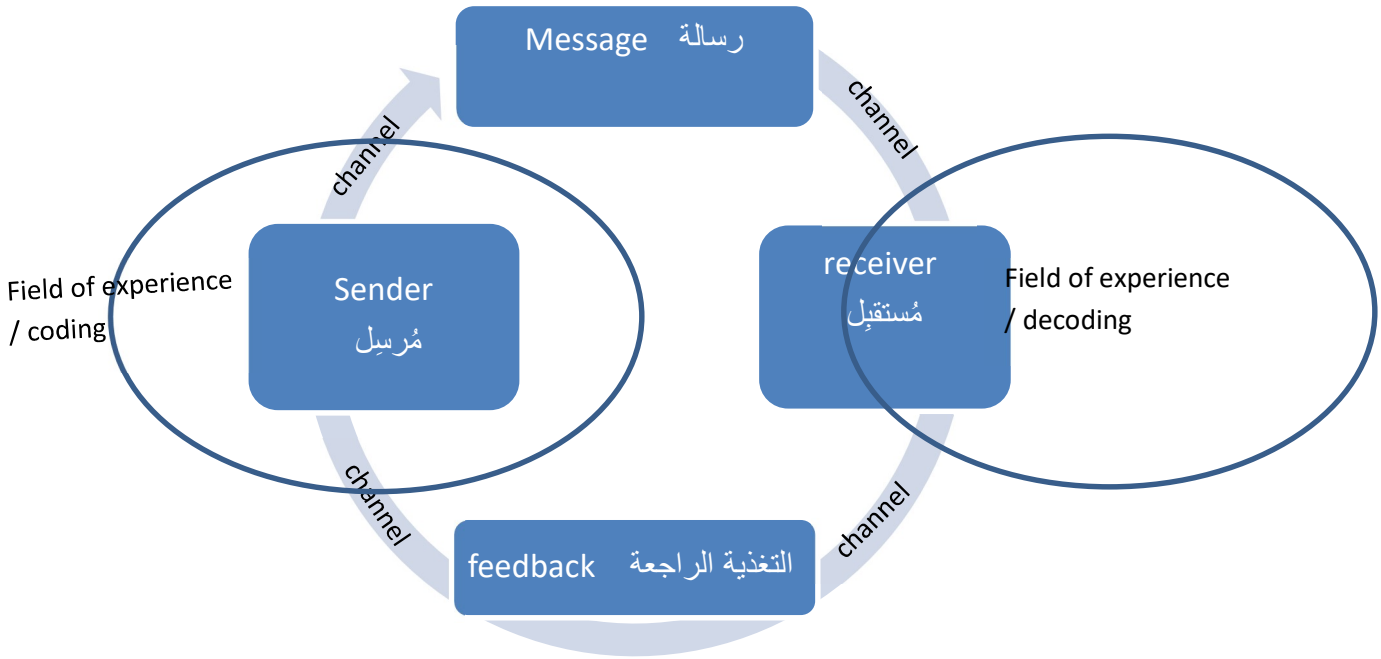
The heart is referring to the need to not only hear and logically understand the argument or point of the sender, but to also connect empathically to the message and expression, trying to *feel* the message. This is very much connected to the other aspects, including affirming rephrasing and not least the body language, including eye contact and posture.

Communication

As evident, communication is at the core of dialogue. To be able to do dialogue, one needs to develop a good understanding of how communication works, and practice one's skills in it actively.

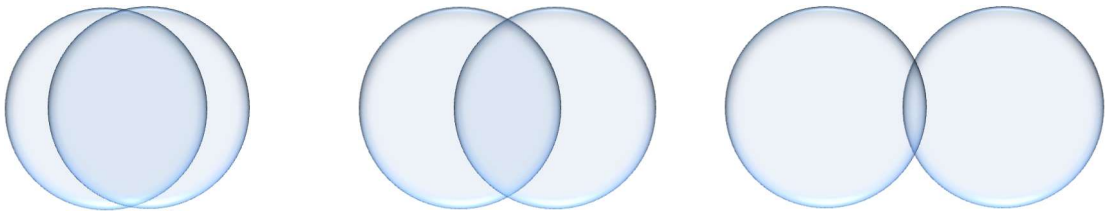
Below is a model of the communication cycle that helps explain how communication between two individuals can be understood:

The communication cycle:



In the **communication cycle** there are two active parts, the **sender** and the **receiver**, which can be understood as person A and person B. The sender sends a **message** through a **communication channel** that is aimed at the receiver, who then needs to give **feedback** to the sender in order for the sender to understand if and how the message was received. Surrounding both the sender and the receiver are **fields of experience** where the message is **coded** (by the sender) and then **de-coded** (by the receiver). In a successful communication, message (and its coding) is well adapted for the receiver; alternatively, the receiver is skillfully decoding the message, and gives feedback back so that both sides make sure that they have understood the message correctly. The important point is here that there are a lot of barriers to the process of communication, which are easy to neglect and often lead to failed communication.

Fields of experience



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Fields of experience refers to the identity and lived experience of individual, where culture, age, gender, career, level of education, nationality and social class, etc. are important factors. Fields of experience overlap between people that have similar identities, experiences and logics (1), but are in most cases more or less

divided (2, 3) which results in different coding and decoding in the communication. Typical examples of this are symbols and humor, and what might be perceived as logical, funny, meaningful, etc.

An example is that a teenage boy from a poor rural area and an urban upper-class older lady might have very different fields of experience and consequently have a harder time in understanding the communication from the other, even if they are from the same country and speak the same language. Two siblings who share the same upbringing in the same neighborhood will often have very similar fields of experience and share references and cultural framework, which will make it the coding and decoding less significant and hence easier for them to understand each other.

However, it is important to remember that similar fields of experience are not the only factors that decide how well two parties communicate, as communication skills goes beyond similarities. With a skillful and careful communication, people with very different fields of experience can still communicate successfully, even though it will require more work on the coding and de-coding.

Communication barriers

There are many obstacles for a smooth and clear communication, both internally and externally.

Lack of feedback is one common problem, as it breaks the circle of communication and makes the sender unsure if the message has reached the receiver in a correct way. This can create frustration and feelings of being ignored or misunderstood, which will limit communication.

Internal noises have to do with the receiver being distant by thinking of other things. This can normally happen in situations of stress, where the person listening has its mind occupied by other concerns and not giving the needed attention to the message from the sender. Several reasons can lead to internal noise. For example, fatigue or hunger, can be a big barrier to communication. In some cases, being distracted or occupied with another issue or concern will play that role of internal noise. Furthermore, conflicts and previous hostilities, or negative attitudes or thoughts towards the speaker can play such a role, highly decreasing the ability to listen to what is really being said. It can also happen in debates, where both parties in the communication is focusing on their own story, preparing a message or countering an argument, hence the attention of the receiver is not focused on listening to and decoding the message. This can lead to a lack of feedback, and a situation where none of the parties really reaches the other with their message. Like mentioned, this is common in debates, where both parts actively try to push their message forward and place focus on what interests them the most, and not on what the other is trying to say.

External noises are similar to internal noises and be as simple as a busy loud environment that takes attention away from the communication, causes stress to one or both of the parties, or simply make it difficult to really hear the message. Examples can be having an important conversation on a crowded bus, or among many people. It can even be a physical barrier that keeps you from seeing the speaker, and hence, keeps you from fully interacting.

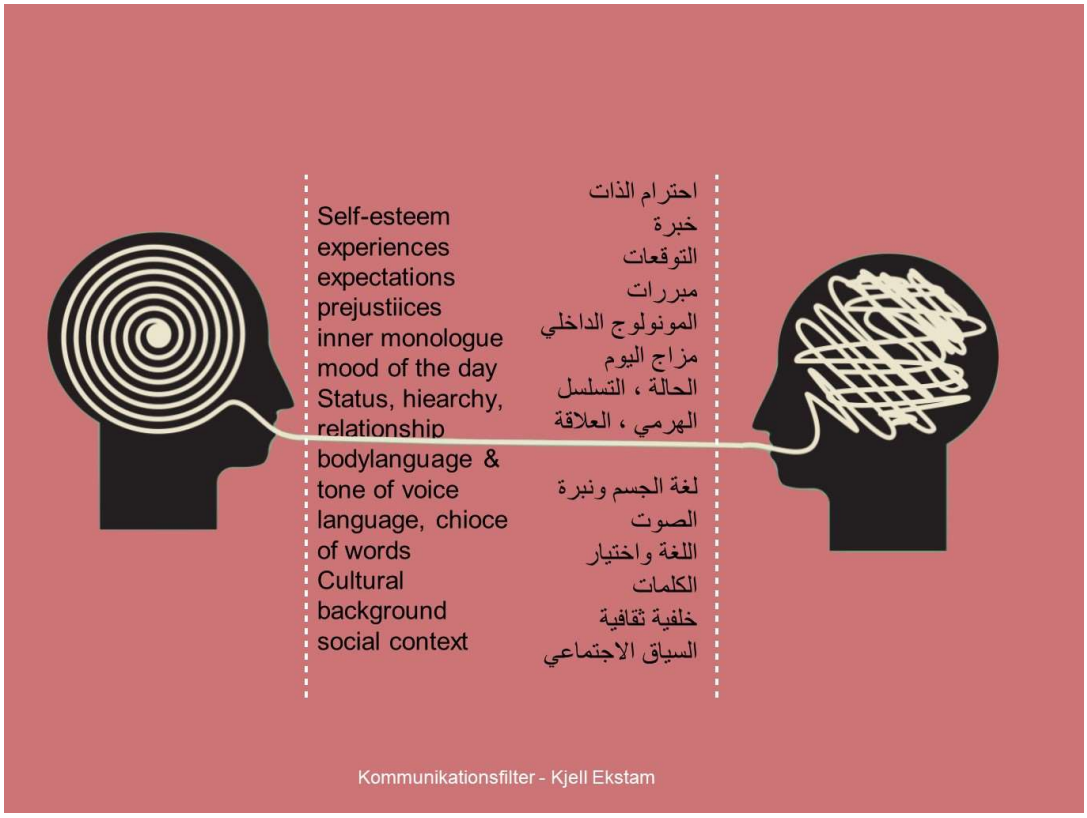
Muddled messages – or unclearly communicated messages - are a barrier to communication because the sender leaves the receiver unclear about the intent of the sender. Muddled messages have many causes. The sender may be confused in his or her thinking, or can disguise sensitive messages in more general terms, something that often relates to cultural norms or less trust towards the receiver or eventual other listeners. Thus the message can be little more than just a vague idea. Feedback from the receiver is the best way for a sender to be sure that the message is clear rather than muddled. Clarifying muddled messages is the responsibility of the sender. The sender hoping the receiver will figure out the message does little to remove this barrier to communication. Effective communication starts with a clear message.

Stereotyping causes us to typify a person, a group, an event or a thing on oversimplified conceptions, beliefs, or opinions. Stereotyping can often substitute for thinking, analysis and open mindedness to a new situation. Stereotyping is a barrier to communication when it causes people to act as if they already know the message that is coming from the sender or worse, as if no message is necessary because "everybody already knows." Both senders and listeners should continuously look for and address thinking, conclusions and actions based on stereotypes.

Wrong channels - Variation of *channels* helps the receiver understand the nature and importance of a message. A written disciplinary warning for tardiness emphasizes to the employee that the problem is serious. A birthday card to an employee's spouse is more sincere than a request to the employee to say "Happy Birthday" to the spouse. A sender should use the appropriate channel for the message s/he is intending to send.

The use of language - Words are not reality. Words, as the sender understands them are combined with the perceptions of those words by the receiver. Language represents only part of the whole. We fill in the rest with perceptions. Trying to understand a foreign language easily demonstrates words not being reality. Being "foreign" is not limited to the language of another country. It can be the language of another culture within the same country or society from where you are from. The solution is feedback

Lack of feedback - Feedback is the mirror of communication. Feedback mirrors what the sender has sent. Feedback is the receiver sending back to the sender the message as perceived. Without feedback, communication is one-way. Feedback may be as subtle as a stare, a puzzled look, a nod, or failure to ask any questions after complicated instructions have been given. Both sender and receiver can play an active role in using feedback to make communication truly two-way. Feedback should be helpful rather than hurtful. Prompt feedback is more effective than feedback saved up until the "right" moment. Feedback should deal in specifics rather than generalities



This picture describes the many barriers that might block communication between two parties trying to communicate.

Nonviolent communication

One useful tool of communication in a dialogue process is called *Nonviolent communication*. This method is extensive and hard to cover in its full scope, but we pick out a few pieces to use in dialogue process. In brief, it builds on deconstructing a message and sending it in a non-hostile yet clear way, avoiding to putt blame or stereotyping of groups or issues. Nonviolent communication emphasizes that the sender's own perspective is built on their own lived experience and acquired knowledge, thereby being both true (to them) and simultaneously subjective hence not universally true. One simple step is using so called *me-messages*:

- *The way I see it… from my point of view… I think that…*

This subtle opening to a statement makes it more personal and humble to other interpretations and opinions, in comparison to just stating what you think about something that might be controversial, and create a reaction or rejection with the receiver.

Another step in nonviolent communication is to add is further explanation to why you have a certain opinion, perspective, feeling or idea. It can be a short backstory that connects to your lived experience, or information that you have acquired and why or how that knowledge or experience resonates with you - it can play on logical conclusions, emotional reactions, faith or ideological conviction:

- *….I think like this because of my upbringing…. I have learned this in school…. As a practicing religious person, I believe… I have always thought that..*

This way of expression should create a message where the receiver can get an understanding of not only what you think but also why you think like that. This can also be used towards yourself as it forces you as a sender to reflect on your own position or idea. Doing this should not be to relativize your statement, but it should make you reflect on why you think like you do.